

109 Compare leaf structure

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MINS

All plants have leaves, but have you ever noticed how different leaves are? A willow tree's are long and slender. An oak's are lobed. A pine tree's are needle-shaped, while a holly's have spiny edges. Learn about trees in your yard.

What you need

- The leaves in your yard or nearby park

1 First, see if the leaf shape is simple or compound. A simple leaf has just one leaf to a stem, like an oak's. A compound leaf has several leaflets coming off a central stem, like the vine called Virginia creeper.

2 How are the leaves arranged? Some are solitary, but others form in clusters. Some grow opposite from each other. Others alternate.

3 See what kind of textures your leaves have. Are they smooth and waxy, or coarse and rough? Do they have spiny parts or crinkled edges?



110 Track leaf colors

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MINS



Leaves change color as they grow and age. Most start out bright green but turn many different shades before they die. Photograph the same plant leaf every month for a year to see how it changes.

Track the changes